



Work in a socially diverse environment

D1.HRS.CL1.19

D1.HOT.CL1.02

D2.TCC.CL1.02

Trainee Manual



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Trainee Manual

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Introduction to trainee manual

To the Trainee

Congratulations on joining this course. This Trainee Manual is one part of a 'toolbox' which is a resource provided to trainees, trainers and assessors to help you become competent in various areas of your work.

The 'toolbox' consists of three elements:

- A Trainee Manual for you to read and study at home or in class
- A Trainer Guide with Power Point slides to help your Trainer explain the content of the training material and provide class activities to help with practice
- An Assessment Manual which provides your Assessor with oral and written questions and other assessment tasks to establish whether or not you have achieved competency.

The first thing you may notice is that this training program and the information you find in the Trainee Manual seems different to the textbooks you have used previously. This is because the method of instruction and examination is different. The method used is called Competency based training (CBT) and Competency based assessment (CBA). CBT and CBA is the training and assessment system chosen by ASEAN (Association of South-East Asian Nations) to train people to work in the tourism and hospitality industry throughout all the ASEAN member states.

What is the CBT and CBA system and why has it been adopted by ASEAN?

CBT is a way of training that concentrates on what a worker can do or is required to do at work. The aim of the training is to enable trainees to perform tasks and duties at a standard expected by employers. CBT seeks to develop the skills, knowledge and attitudes (or recognise the ones the trainee already possesses) to achieve the required competency standard. ASEAN has adopted the CBT/CBA training system as it is able to produce the type of worker that industry is looking for and this therefore increases trainees chances of obtaining employment.

CBA involves collecting evidence and making a judgement of the extent to which a worker can perform his/her duties at the required competency standard. Where a trainee can already demonstrate a degree of competency, either due to prior training or work experience, a process of 'Recognition of Prior Learning' (RPL) is available to trainees to recognise this. Please speak to your trainer about RPL if you think this applies to you.

What is a competency standard?

Competency standards are descriptions of the skills and knowledge required to perform a task or activity at the level of a required standard.

242 competency standards for the tourism and hospitality industries throughout the ASEAN region have been developed to cover all the knowledge, skills and attitudes required to work in the following occupational areas:

- Housekeeping
- Food Production
- Food and Beverage Service

- Front Office
- Travel Agencies
- Tour Operations.

All of these competency standards are available for you to look at. In fact you will find a summary of each one at the beginning of each Trainee Manual under the heading 'Unit Descriptor'. The unit descriptor describes the content of the unit you will be studying in the Trainee Manual and provides a table of contents which are divided up into 'Elements' and 'Performance Criteria'. An element is a description of one aspect of what has to be achieved in the workplace. The 'Performance Criteria' below each element details the level of performance that needs to be demonstrated to be declared competent.

There are other components of the competency standard:

- *Unit Title*: statement about what is to be done in the workplace
- *Unit Number*: unique number identifying the particular competency
- *Nominal hours*: number of classroom or practical hours usually needed to complete the competency. We call them 'nominal' hours because they can vary e.g. sometimes it will take an individual less time to complete a unit of competency because he/she has prior knowledge or work experience in that area.

The final heading you will see before you start reading the Trainee Manual is the 'Assessment Matrix'. Competency based assessment requires trainees to be assessed in at least 2 – 3 different ways, one of which must be practical. This section outlines three ways assessment can be carried out and includes work projects, written questions and oral questions. The matrix is designed to show you which performance criteria will be assessed and how they will be assessed. Your trainer and/or assessor may also use other assessment methods including 'Observation Checklist' and 'Third Party Statement'. An observation checklist is a way of recording how you perform at work and a third party statement is a statement by a supervisor or employer about the degree of competence they believe you have achieved. This can be based on observing your workplace performance, inspecting your work or gaining feedback from fellow workers.

Your trainer and/or assessor may use other methods to assess you such as:

- Journals
- Oral presentations
- Role plays
- Log books
- Group projects
- Practical demonstrations.

Remember your trainer is there to help you succeed and become competent. Please feel free to ask him or her for more explanation of what you have just read and of what is expected from you and best wishes for your future studies and future career in tourism and hospitality.

Unit descriptor

Work in a socially diverse environment

This unit deals with the skills and knowledge required to Work in a socially diverse environment in a range of settings within the hotel and travel industries workplace context.

Unit Code:

D1.HRS.CL1.19
D1.HOT.CL1.02
D2.TCC.CL1.02

Nominal Hours:

25 hours

Element 1: Communicate with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds

Performance Criteria

- 1.1 Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups and treat them with respect and sensitivity
- 1.2 Take into consideration cultural differences in all verbal and non-verbal communication
- 1.3 Attempt to overcome language barriers
- 1.4 Obtain assistance from colleagues, reference books or outside organisations when required

Element 2: Deal with cross cultural misunderstandings

Performance Criteria

- 2.1 Identify issues which may cause conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace
- 2.2 Address difficulties with the appropriate people and seek assistance from team leaders or others where required
- 2.3 Consider possible cultural differences when difficulties or misunderstandings occur
- 2.4 Make efforts to resolve misunderstandings, taking account of cultural considerations
- 2.5 Refer issues and problems to the appropriate team leader/supervisor for follow up

Assessment matrix

Showing mapping of Performance Criteria against Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions

The Assessment Matrix indicates three of the most common assessment activities your Assessor may use to assess your understanding of the content of this manual and your performance - Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions. It also indicates where you can find the subject content related to these assessment activities in the Trainee Manual (i.e. under which element or performance criteria). As explained in the Introduction, however, the assessors are free to choose which assessment activities are most suitable to best capture evidence of competency as they deem appropriate for individual students.

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 1: Insert element				
1.1	Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups and treat them with respect and sensitivity	1.1	1,2	1
1.2	Take into consideration cultural differences in all verbal and non-verbal communication	1.2	3,4	2
1.3	Attempt to overcome language barriers	1.3	5,6	3
1.4	Obtain assistance from colleagues, reference books or outside organisations when required	1.4	7,8	4
Element 2: Deal with cross cultural misunderstandings				
2.1	Identify issues which may cause conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace	2.1	9,10	5
2.2	Address difficulties with the appropriate people and seek assistance from team leaders or others where required	2.2	11,12	6
2.3	Consider possible cultural differences when difficulties or misunderstandings occur	2.3	13,14	7
2.4	Make efforts to resolve misunderstandings, taking account of cultural considerations	2.4	15,16	8
2.5	Refer issues and problems to the appropriate team leader/supervisor for follow up	2.4	17,18	9

Glossary

Term	Explanation
ASEAN Countries	Association of South East Asian Nations incorporating Brunei Darussalam, Cambodia, Indonesia, Lao PDR, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand and Vietnam
Carer	To watch over; be responsible for
Communication	The imparting or interchange of thoughts, opinions, or information by speech, writing, or signs
Conflict	To come into collision or disagreement; be contradictory, at variance, or in opposition; clash
Culture	The behaviours and beliefs characteristic of a particular social, ethnic, or age group
Diversity	A point of difference
EO	Equal Opportunity
External customer	Customers come from outside the business
Immigration	The movement of non-native people into a country in order to settle there
Internal customer	Other staff, workers and colleagues from within the business
Language	Body of words and the systems for their use common to a people who are of the same community or nation, the same geographical area, or the same cultural tradition
Misunderstanding	Failure to understand correctly; mistake as to meaning or intent; a disagreement or quarrel
OSH	Occupational Safety and Health
Protocols	The customs and regulations dealing with diplomatic formality, precedence, and etiquette
Race	A group of persons related by common descent or heredity
Respect	To hold in esteem or honour; to show regard or consideration for
Stereotype	A set of inaccurate, simplistic generalizations about a group that allows others to categorize them and treat them accordingly

Term	Explanation
Scope of authority	The level of responsibility and action an individual has in relation to handling an issue
Sensitivity	Being able to show consideration toward another
Sign Language	Also called sign. any of several visual-gestural systems of communication, especially employing manual gestures, as used among deaf people

Element 1:

Communicate with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds

1.1 Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups and treat them with respect and sensitivity

Introduction

The hospitality and tourism industries are leading examples of multicultural industries.

Many workplaces are staffed with people from various cultures. Also staff interacts with and serves people from different nations and cultural backgrounds.

It is vital that all these people, whether staff and customers, are treated with respect and sensitivity.



The diversity of customers and colleagues

People are different.

There are a number of things that make us all different, including:

- The way they live – including where and how they live
- Values and principles – the importance placed on people, actions and things, and personal guidelines for living life
- Educational background – how far they got through schooling, and whether or not they did any further education
- Sporting interests – whether they play sport, or whether they are even interested in sport and which sport
- Food and beverage tastes – do they drink alcohol or prefer juice, do they eat red meat or are they vegetarian?
- Lifestyle background – what car do they drive, where have they worked?
- Place of birth – which country where they born in?
- Styles of communication – what is their preferred communication medium and method?
- Religious beliefs – who or what do they believe in?
- What is their preferred language?



All of these factors and a whole lot more, combine to produce a world full of different people. It is critical to remember that just because these people are different to you doesn't make them any better or worse. They are just different.

In your industry workplace you must, therefore, make sure that any personal bias is not allowed to adversely influence and affect the way you interact with such individuals.

In an industry that is such a strong service-oriented industry there is absolutely no room for prejudice.

Prejudice relates to holding a personal bias or point of view that disposes you to prejudging a person or situation rather than deal with the facts.



Valuing customers and colleagues

An essential element of working in a socially diverse environment is to make sure that customers and colleagues feel valued.

This means making sure that they know and that we demonstrate in practical terms that those people are important to the business and that the business appreciates their presence.

As an individual worker within a business you must therefore make sure other staff understand that you place worth on their:

- Working abilities and skills
- Workplace and product knowledge
- Experience within the industry, customers and other relevant stakeholders including management, authorities and suppliers
- Their contribution to discussions – such as Occupational Safety and Health (OSH), general work planning, suggestions and input to daily workplace activities
- Achievement of team and workplace goals.



The key to doing this is that the value you place on these co-workers should be based on them as an individual and not influenced by any irrelevant issues such as age, gender, race or disabilities.

Make sure all customers understand you place worth on their:

- Presence on the premises
- The money they spend with us
- The other customers they bring to the business.



Respect and sensitivity

Respect and sensitivity are two of the characteristics we should display towards colleagues and customers when demonstrating the value we place on them.

Respect

So what is involved in demonstrating respect for other workers, and for towards customers?

Respect means:

- Holding that person in high regard for who they are, not what they are – acknowledging them for being who they are
- Being deferential in the way the person is treated – as in the saying ‘treating the person with respect’
- Showing courtesy to the person.



Sensitivity

The second part in valuing others is to be genuinely sensitive to their personal individual needs where they have special needs based on their cultural diversity.

In many ways showing sensitivity is more difficult than being respectful because it takes more time and more commitment.

Being sensitive to the cultural needs of others involves:

- Identifying what their cultural or social background is
- Determining what special considerations should be given to that person
- Taking action to ensure that their specific cultural needs are met to the best of your ability, in-line with your other work-related obligations.



In essence, being sensitive means knowing that another person merits consideration based on their cultural or social background, and accommodating that need.

Being sensitive is the exact opposite of knowing that a social or cultural need exists and ignoring it!

Internal and external customers

Customers come from outside the business and may be referred to as ‘external’ customers. That is, they are external to the business.

By contrast, ‘internal’ customers are other staff, workers and colleagues from within the business.

This allows us to regard all people with whom we interact as customers. This is useful as it underlines the need for us to treat everyone in the workplace with respect and sensitivity

It is very true that a business does not exist except for its customers but it is easy to forget this and to forget how essential customers (internal and external) are to all businesses.

Different cultural groups

Employees

In your working life in the industry it is possible that you will function alongside people from a variety of different culture. Some of these will be first generation and many will be second or third generation.

In lots of cases it will be obvious by virtue of appearance and language that they have a different background, but in many other cases this will not be so obvious.

Our industry traditionally employs people from many countries either as full-time staff who have residency in the country, or as those working on visas.

Locations from which these people arrive include:

- ASEAN countries
- Other Asian countries
- European Community countries
- Middle Eastern countries
- Subcontinent Countries
- North & South American countries
- African Countries
- Oceania Countries.



Tourists

ASEAN countries receive tourists ('visitors') from many of the above mentioned regions and their respective countries.

With the ever-increasing number of overseas travellers to Asia, it is important that we know a little about the people who are likely to be our customers.

Every hospitality and tourism business, along with each ASEAN country, will have specific countries from which their customers come from. It is important that the organisation and their staff understand the profile of their customers, so they can tailor their products and services accordingly.

Learning about different cultural requirements

Knowing about the various cultural differences that exist does not come naturally.

The first requirement in learning about these differences is a desire to find out about how these cultures vary, and how you can accommodate those needs. Without this individual wish to find out information it is rare that industry employees will ever successfully be able to work effectively with people from socially and culturally diverse environments.

In practical terms, the following can assist in finding out what is culturally appropriate for the people with whom you may be required to work or interact.



Attend a cultural awareness program

These have become very popular over recent years and are structured programs that guide you through the lifestyles and backgrounds of various cultures.

Some establishments conduct regular, compulsory in-house cultural awareness programs especially where they have lots of staff or customers from a certain country.

These classes explain cultural needs, wants and preferences and advise you in relation to a range of things such as:

- Basic greetings and phrases
- Body language of that country – what is acceptable and what is not, what may be offensive and things to avoid
- General expectations of people from that country – in terms of service, formality, food and beverages, visitor expectations
- History of their country
- Basic geographical awareness
- Contributions made by that country to the world
- Religious issues and observations
- Values and value systems
- Customs and taboos
- Beliefs
- Role and importance of family.



Talk to people from different cultures and countries

Naturally this can be difficult where there is language issue, but in many cases you should be able to find someone from a culture that speaks your language and will be all too willing to explain their culture to you.

Many people are eager to share their culture when they find an interested person.

You might find a suitable person:

- On the staff where you work
- Amongst the customers you deal with
- Amongst your friends
- Amongst the network of contacts you should start developing as part of your professional role within the industry
- Working with an industry stakeholder – this may be a supplier, service agency, government body or peak industry body.



Many cultures have clubs or groups in different locations and a phone call to them can often quickly answer any query you might have.

Many of them will be willing to arrange for a speaker to come and talk to staff where you work, often at no charge, because they see part of their role as promoting an understanding of their culture within your country.

Reading books, watching DVDs and getting on-line

There are lots of excellent books about different cultures and newspapers can also be a great source of information.

Travel documentaries provide a good background for understanding too.

Searching the 'net for various cultures or support services is also a good way to go.



Visit embassies and consulates of various countries

You may wish to visit the embassies or consulates of key countries that are important to your business. They will be able to provide you with literature or may be able to meet and chat to you.

1.2 Take into consideration cultural differences in all verbal and non-verbal communication

Introduction

Working in a socially diverse environment necessitates communicating with people from different cultural and social backgrounds.

This must be done, as we have already seen, in a respectful and sensitive manner.

An essential aspect of this need is to ensure that the two components of communication, verbal language and body language, are appropriate to the person and culture being communicated with.



Cultural differences

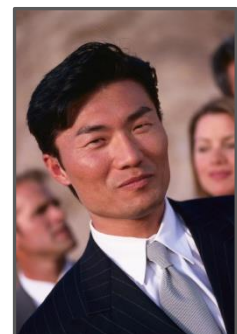
The cultural differences that you must ensure you take into account may relate to:

Race

The first basic fact to identify when communicating with people from another culture is to identify their race. That is, the country they come from.

This is the primary indicator of what needs that person has in terms of their workplace needs for staff or their product and service needs for customers.

You can determine their race by simply and politely asking them. This shows interest and helps demonstrate a willingness to accommodate their special needs.



Language

People from different countries may have trouble with your language. There is sometimes an expectation on our part that people from another country should speak your language but this is a false and dangerous assumption and one that is without basis.

In addition those who have knowledge of your language can have trouble understanding you because of accents and local expressions.

It is generally accepted that we should:

- Speak slower to overseas people
- Avoid the use of industry jargon, local terms and expressions
- Try to learn some basic phrases in other languages
- Provide written information in a variety of languages. Where deemed necessary, many establishments provide a range of service information including maps, price lists, facilities and menus etc in different languages to assist in this regard.

Many places also employ multi- or bi-lingual staff to help.

Special needs

Special needs commonly occur in relation to:

- Food
- Privacy
- Religious devotion
- Beverages
- Sleeping requirements
- Business protocols.



Where a workplace regularly receives guests from certain countries, there will usually be some form of in-house training and resources that assist you in offering services that are appropriate to meet these special needs.

Where these supports are not available, it is acceptable to ask the person what special needs they have and how you can assist them in meeting those needs.

The more you make the effort to meet these needs for customers, the better you and the establishment will be regarded and the greater will be the likelihood of repeat business from those people and referral business from those whom they recommend to us.

The more you meet these needs for colleagues, the greater will be the level of cooperation you receive from such people, and the more respect they will in turn have for you.

Family structure

The orientation we have to 'the family' in your country may well be at odds with what visitors from other cultures hold dear to them.

The point being that we need to be respectful of the needs of others.

Family structure refers to the relationships that exist within families for the members of that family. It covers how family members treat each other, how they speak to each other, the freedom that family members are given, the roles of members of the family and the responsibilities that members are allocated or assumed to discharge.



Your perspective on family structure may not be the same as those from other cultures.

For example, different countries will have a different awareness and acceptance of:

- The nuclear family – where two generations of a family live together either by design or as a result of externally imposed need
- Step-families – where family units combine after divorce and there are children in the family from spouses who may not be in that family
- Single-parent families – where the family unit comprises only one parent plus a child or children.

This highlights the differences that can exist between cultures and again underlines that we must take care not to assume that our orientation to something will automatically be the same position taken by others.

This doesn't make them wrong and us right, it just makes them different.

Disabilities

Whilst many of us encounter problems communicating with people suffering from certain disabilities, this problem is hugely compounded when the individual concerned is from another culture.

The keys are to:

- Identify the disabilities that colleagues and customers commonly present with
- Plan how to accommodate these needs – by talking to support groups and talking to disabled people to learn about their needs, expectations and how they prefer to be treated
- Implement the pre-planned strategies sensitively – meaning there is always a need to fine-tune service to meet specific individual need.

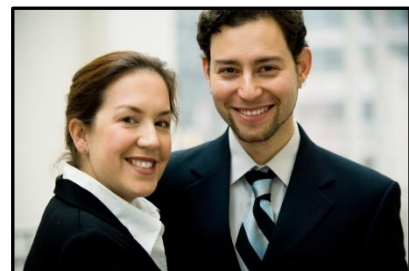


Gender

The equality experienced in your country may not be as strongly shared by people from other nations.

While many countries will have some form of equal opportunity legislation which purports to treat males and females equally, this arrangement does not exist within all cultures.

It is our role when dealing with people from another culture is to recognise this difference and accommodate it. It is not our role to try to force those people to align with your view in this regard.



While we may see it as acceptable to talk directly to a female customer, making direct eye contact and smiling to them, other countries may find this approach rude, offensive and indicative of sexual overtones.

Age

In some countries it may be the case that old age confers respect and prestige while in other countries it may be the young people who are regarded with respect and prestige.

In each country laws govern the treatment of people on the basis of age but these laws may not apply elsewhere.

We must be sensitive to these age-related considerations and treat each culture appropriately based on their traditional approach to age.

We need to sensitively apply any legal requirements that apply to age-related issues, such as the service of alcohol, which may be different in different countries.



Sexual preference

Sexual preference is not the taboo it once was in some countries; however we need to be mindful of not giving offence to people who are different in this way.

We also need to be mindful of not imposing our liberal approach in this regard onto others.

Law and Culture

All people should be valued and treated with respect when it comes to their individual differences.

Equal Opportunity (EO) legislation has been devised in some countries to be enforced in society in general with specific emphasis on activities in all workplaces.

These laws which may not exist in all countries can vary between different countries but remain essentially the same, identifying features that may cause prejudices among groups of people.



Discrimination means unfair treatment of a person based on prejudices.

In many countries it is against the law to treat anyone unfairly or harass them.

Whether or not you agree with this legislation if it exists in your country you need to know what it covers and abide by it.

Objectives of EO legislation

In part, the objectives of EO legislation are to:

- To promote recognition and acceptance of everyone's right to equality of opportunity
- To eliminate, as far as possible, discrimination against people by prohibiting discrimination on the basis of various 'listed attributes' (see immediately below)
- To eliminate, as far as possible, sexual harassment.



The 'listed attributes'

The seventeen listed attributes are:

- Age
- Breastfeeding
- Carer status
- Disability/impairment
- Gender identity
- Industrial activity
- Lawful sexual activity
- Marital status
- Parental status
- Physical features – covering height, weight, size, shape or any other physical characteristics: safety-based discrimination may be okay to protect health, safety or property
- Political belief or activity
- Pregnancy
- Race
- Religious belief or activity
- Sex/gender
- Sexual orientation
- Personal association (assumed or actual) with anyone who has one or more of the above characteristics.

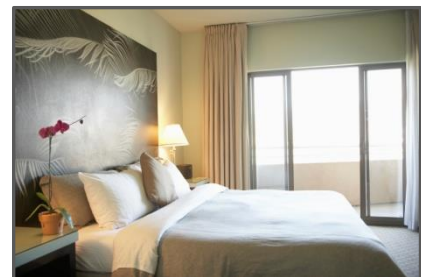


Areas of public life

In addition to the above identified listed personal characteristics, a breach of the EO legislation can only occur when the unfair treatment takes place within one of the identified areas of public life identified by the legislation.

These areas of public life are:

- Accommodation
- Clubs
- Education
- Employment
- Provision of goods and services
- Selling or transferring land
- Sport.



As you can see, this means that many of our dealings with customers in the hospitality, tourism and events industries are potentially covered by the requirements of EO legislation.

Stereotypes

When dealing with people it is important not to use stereotypes.

Never assume that someone fits into a particular category, simply based on what you think is the case based on personal observation, information given to you by other staff, your personal experience or your individual perspectives.

Some incorrect stereotypes may include:

- Assuming an older man is taking his daughter out to lunch, when really the woman is his girlfriend or wife
- Assuming elderly people are boring and conservative
- Assuming all teenagers are wild and talk nonsense
- Assuming all Americans will tip
- Assuming all Japanese people drink sake
- Assuming two men will not want a double room
- Assuming a woman in her fifties is not the mother of a young child
- Assuming your manager thinks he is better than you
- Assuming a woman and a man are married or are in a relationship
- Assuming all men like to drink their beer and women drink champagne.



Verbal and non-verbal communication

There is more accommodation between cultures regarding problems, difficulties and misunderstanding today than there was several decades ago.

The reason for this is the way in which the world has shrunk due to the availability of travel and the massive explosion in global electronic communication.

Regardless, there is always an on-going need for us to be sensitive and respectful in the way we:

- Communicate with others from a different culture
- Interpret the communication we receive from people from another culture.

Keys in factoring in appropriate verbal and non-verbal communication when dealing with people from another culture include:

- Identify the country and culture
- Take time to plan what to say and how to say it
- Be mindful of your body language – most non-verbal communication is spontaneous
- Avoid industry and establishment jargon
- Avoid local expressions
- Avoid complex statements
- Give the person your full attention



- Use alternative communication strategies to support the verbal communication
- Be alert to feedback from the other person – especially in regard to identifying when something you may have said or done has given unintended offence.

More information

Check out the following:

- <http://www2.andrews.edu/~tidwell/bsad560/NonVerbal.html>
- <http://www.csupomona.edu/~tassi/gestures.htm>
- <http://www.ling.gu.se/~biljana/gestures2.html>
- <http://www.spanishprograms.com/spanish-culture.htm>
- http://stephan.dahl.at/nonverbal/culture_and_nonverbal.html
- <http://www.ialf.edu/kipbipa/papers/MuhamadHandiGunawan.doc>
- <http://www.cba.uni.edu/buscomm/nonverbal/Culture.htm>
- http://www.beyondintractability.org/essay/cross-cultural_communication/
- <http://www.bettercommunicationresults.com.au/nonverbal-communication.html>.



1.3 Attempt to overcome language barriers

Introduction

Providing the goodwill exists on your part to communicate with a person from another background, this can usually be successfully accomplished.

It will take a little extra time and will demand a little extra effort but it can normally be done.

There is no doubt that most failures to communicate between cultures are because one of the parties made no real and honest attempt to do so.

The role of planning and preparation

Very few attempts at overcoming language barriers will be successful unless there has been appropriate and sufficient planning and preparation: these can be seen as essential pre-requisites.

You should identify the languages that need to be taken into account. There are often more than just one, but often not more than three or four. Once these have been identified, develop phrases that will allow you to:

- Meet, greet and farewell customers – at different times of the day, and to different types of customers including men, women, children and business people
- Provide simple directions – to the restaurant, bar, swimming pool, different floors, various rooms as well as to common landmarks and tourist attractions
- Give simple instructions – on how to use telephones, how to operate in-room and venue facilities



- Answer simple enquiries – such as questions relating to availability of rooms, process of goods and services and local conditions
- Prepare for, serve and assist customers – in accordance with your designated work role and responsibilities. For instance, the language needs of a front office receptionist will differ to those of a room attendant which will be, in turn, different to those required by a food and beverage waiter or a bar attendant
- Describe goods and service – once again this will relate to your specific workplace role. For example, a food waiter should be able to describe tastes, smells, ingredients, cooking styles, portion sizes and so on.

Once you have developed these phrases you will need to practice them. Conducting role plays with staff from another country are a good idea and use them in the workplace whenever the opportunity arises.

Verbal communication

Having a second language skill is looked upon favourably by hospitality, tourism and events employers.

It is certainly a valuable tool when dealing directly with foreign customers, within the limitations of local accents, dialects and colloquialisms.

When speaking to a person from a different culture, it is important to take into consideration their particular cultural differences.

This can include:

- Pitch or tone of your voice
- Volume of the talking
- Speed at which you talk
- Pauses in the conversation - to allow for understanding, questions to be asked, clarification.



When coming face-to-face with customers who speak another language, it is important to slow your speech, but not too slow to the point of sounding unnatural or giving the other person the impression that you think they are stupid!

Always try to deliver your thoughts using basic words and sentence constructions.

Remember that there are times when it is socially acceptable to say a particular word, while in other circles the same language could be considered unacceptable.

Be careful when choosing your words, as confusion can result in cultural misunderstandings. Always try to modify your language to suit the listener as much as possible.

Keep smiling! Your efforts at trying to help will shine through even though you may make an unintentional cultural gaff.

Simple words in foreign languages

There is no expectation that you learn words in every language but you should identify countries from which co-workers and/or customers come and learn some simple words and phrases.

The more you learn, the easier other words and phrases will become.

Make a start by learning simple words as follows:

- To greet and welcome
- To farewell and say goodbye
- Count the numbers 1 – 10
- The days of the week and months of the year
- Titles used by people including Mister and Missus
- Basic functions – walk, drive, sleep, eat and drink
- Basic establishment facilities
- Basic products and services
- Methods of transportation.



It can be useful to prepare a hard copy list that you can refer to, or to have a range of dual language dictionaries or phrase books.

Never be afraid to try to communicate in foreign languages. Most people appreciate you making the effort even though your pronunciation may be wrong, or there is still a lack of clear understanding.

You don't need to attend a formal course to learn these basic words or terms; you just need to have the desire to do so. You can learn the above from:

- Customers
- The internet
- A foreign language dictionary
- Staff
- A local ethnic club or association.



Non-verbal communication

Non-verbal communication occurs in all person-to-person situations.

Some people use more non-verbal communication than others, though we all use it to some degree.

Some people read non-verbal communication than others, but everyone forms an impression about the speaker based on their interpretation of their body language.

Non-verbal communication is traditionally more important when communicating with someone from a culturally diverse background where there is a spoken word language difficulty.

Types of non-verbal communication

Your stance and posture may be interpreted as:

- Shoulders back – positive attitude
- Shoulders slumped forward – negative attitude.



The speed with which you move may be interpreted as:

- Slow walk – don't care
- Fast walk – flat out and stressed.

Your facial expression may be interpreted as:

- Grumpy face – don't want to be at work; don't like the person they are talking to
- Smiling face – happy with life; happy to work with customers.

How you hold your arms may be interpreted as:

- Arms crossed – defensive
- Arms at your side – open to discussion

Hand and finger gestures may be interpreted as:

- Waving a hand – saying goodbye
- Curling a finger - beckoning
- The thumbs up – all is okay or some other more abusive message!

How you attend to your personal hygiene may be interpreted as:

- Bad body odour – don't care attitude; disrespect for others
- Hair tied back neatly – person with pride; respect for others.

Eye contact may be interpreted as:

- Direct eye contact – telling the truth, intimidating, sexual
- No eye contact – not listening, disinterested or lying.

When using body language, be aware that you can also be transmitting feelings, which could be interpreted as conflicting with your words.

It is important to be consciously aware of your own body language and that of others at all times when communicating.

Language barriers - the role of gestures

When faced with a language barrier, service staff should attempt to communicate through the use of gestures or simple words.

While this is obviously not a perfect situation, it does at least show your desire to communicate.

Gestures are preferable to saying nothing and risking the person feeling ignored.

Attempts at gestures may include:

- Pointing to indicate a location, a position or a menu item
- Holding fingers up to establish quantities
- Rubbing your hands to indicate temperature
- Nodding your head in agreement



- Shaking your head in disagreement
- Using facial expressions to relay your feelings.

Written communication

Where there is a problem with dialects or perhaps the customer cannot understand your accent, you may still be able to communicate but do so in writing.

This can be especially true where staff have studied a second language. They can be reasonably competent with the written word but yet to develop their competency with the spoken word due to speed or accents.

The use of pre-prepared written documents developed in various other languages is a great idea.



Sign language

When communicating with deaf people, it can be extremely useful to be able to use sign language. It may be worthwhile learning a few signs to help communicate.

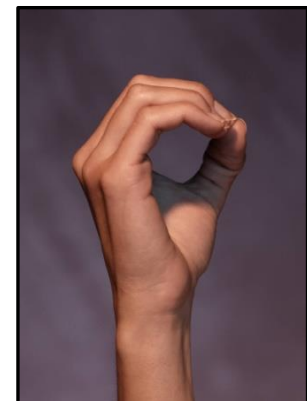
1.4 Obtain assistance from colleagues, reference books or outside organisations when required

Introduction

Unless you have indicated to your employer that you have competencies with certain languages, no business will expect you to be proficiently communicate with people from other countries.

They will, however, expect you to make an effort to learn the basics that will enable you to do your job properly.

To learn the basics you will need to get help from other people, various agencies or external organisations. This section looks at where you might obtain such assistance.



Colleagues

You may be able to get help from co-workers or in-house trainers.

Where a colleague is from a different speaking country, simply ask them to give you some lessons that cover basic words or phrases that may be helpful.

This may be informal 'training' but it can be very effective, and is a great way of demonstrating to them (and management) that you have an interest in their culture and in serving people from that country.



Customers

Never be afraid to ask customers to help you out, especially where the customer has good language skills.

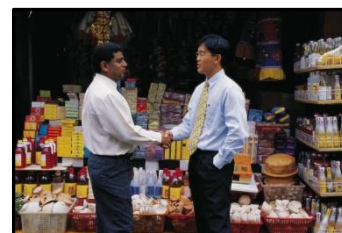
Make sure you don't impose on them or their time but they will usually accommodate a request for either a very quick verbal 'lesson' or a couple of written words or phrases.



Other people

In addition, you can seek information on different cultures and possibly get some language-related assistance from:

- Teachers – in-house and industry trainers
- Family, friends and acquaintances
- Service providers – private and public
- Suppliers
- Supervisors.



Sign Language Companies

Sign Language companies provide training used for communicating with deaf people.

Translating and Interpreting Service

A Translating and Interpreting Service (TIS) may be useful if your organisation deals with lots of people from different language speaking backgrounds, also known as people from 'culturally and linguistically diverse backgrounds'.

Written information

Written information about different cultures and countries may be found through:

- The Internet – type key words or phrases in the search engine
- Media – especially newspapers, radio stations and magazines that are specific to certain countries
- Local cultural centres
- Local library – books and electronic formats
- Language centres
- Hospitality, industry and events industry groups or organisations
- Government or private training and educational providers
- Purchased or borrowed books.



Outside organisations

We have already mentioned some of the external organisations that may be able to help. They include:

- Interpreter services –private interpreters are also available on a fee-for-service basis
- Diplomatic services – various embassies can provide advice on where to obtain specific detailed information on languages and cultures. They may also have 'Fact Sheets' or similar that can be mailed or e-mailed to you. Some embassies may be able to provide on-the-spot interpretation of emergency language needs
- Appropriate government agencies
- Individual agencies specific to unique needs
- Department of Immigration and Citizenship
- Educational institutions – both public and private. These institutions can only be expected to provide advice and information to enrolled and fee-paying students or a commercial fee-for-service basis
- Disability advocacy groups.



Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 1.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to explain how you can:
 - Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups
 - Treat people with respect and sensitivity.
 - 1.2. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify how to:
 - Identify different types of cultural differences
 - Take these cultural differences into consideration when providing service
 - Use verbal and non-verbal communication to help communication.
 - 1.3. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify how to:
 - Attempt to overcome language barriers using examples and documentation.
 - 1.4. To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:
 - How to obtain assistance from colleagues including types of assistance they can provide
 - Specific reference books or websites that can be helpful when communicating with people from diverse backgrounds.
-

Summary

Communicate with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds

Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups and treat them with respect and sensitivity:

- The diversity of customers and colleagues
- Valuing customers and colleagues
- Respect and sensitivity
- Internal and external customers
- Different cultural groups
- Learning about different cultural requirements.

Take into consideration cultural differences in all verbal and non-verbal communication:

- Cultural differences
- Law and Culture
- Stereotypes
- Verbal and non-verbal communication
- More information.

Attempt to overcome language barriers:

- The role of planning and preparation
- Verbal communication
- Non-verbal communication
- Written communication
- Sign language.

Obtain assistance from colleagues, reference books or outside organisations when required:

- Colleagues
- Customers
- Other People
- Sign Language Companies
- Translating and Interpreting Service
- Written information
- Outside organisations.

Element 2: Deal with cross cultural misunderstandings

2.1 Identify issues which may cause conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace

Introduction

It is important for all workplace conflict and misunderstandings to be identified immediately and dealt with on a case-by-case manner that is sensitive and respectful.

This requirement applies to both colleagues and customers.

What is conflict and misunderstanding?

In relation to working effectively and successfully in a socially diverse environment, 'conflict and misunderstanding' must be given a very broad interpretation and definition.

Anything that upsets another person, whether that person is a customer or colleague, can be regarded as a conflict or a misunderstanding. There are degrees of it ranging from being mildly upset all the way through to outright anger and rage.

Addressing workplace conflict and misunderstanding properly and as early as possible seeks to:

- Keep all conflict and misunderstanding at the 'mild' end of the spectrum
- Clarify any perceptions that arose due to misunderstanding
- Rectify the situation to the greatest extent possible, given the circumstances that applied.

Possible causes of conflict and misunderstanding

There are a number of key areas that can cause conflict misunderstanding in the workplace.

Remember that all messages sent, whether verbal or non-verbal, are part of a two-way process.

If a message is not interpreted in the way the sender intended, problems can easily arise.



Difficulties or conflict can also arise out of misunderstandings due to:

- Poor communication
- Lack of communication
- Intolerance
- Impatience
- Poor judgement
- Conflicting personal values, beliefs and opinions
- Personal prejudices.



Examples of situations that can cause conflict or misunderstanding

Misunderstandings may occur when:

- Welcoming guests – due to the body language used or an incorrect attempt to use a foreign language to greet people. The informal or formal manner used by different people can readily give offence or if an Asian or German guest is referred to by their first name. Similarly, a handshake can cause embarrassment to some guests who prefer a brief bow instead
- Giving directions or instructions – where the use of even simple language and gestures leads to confusion or the wrong message being received by the guest
- Answering questions – where the necessary complexity of a response causes misunderstanding and frustration
- Serving customers – for example, offence may be caused in the following situations:



- Offering an alcoholic drink to someone whose religion forbids the consumption of liquor
- Recommending pork or shellfish dishes to certain customers
- Serving beef-based dishes to certain customers



- Describing products, services and facilities – especially where the description is somewhat excessive and leads the guest to false expectations. Many overseas visitors have a strict time constraint on their time and anything that wastes this precious commodity is definitely frowned on
- Working with colleagues – the pressure of work sometimes gives rise to a comment or 'look' that is easily misinterpreted. There is always a need to act professionally while at work in order, amongst other things, to prevent these situations arising
- Socialising with colleagues after work – even in a social setting, it is possible to give unintended offence by a look or a statement that is deemed by the other party to be offensive or inappropriate.

How to identify issues

Issues causing conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace are most commonly identified by:

Personal observation

This is where you notice by seeing or hearing that something you have said or done has upset someone.

Commonly you notice a change in their facial expressions, their demeanour or the way in which they verbally respond to you. This may include either changing their previous attitude to you or shunning you.

You become better at doing this with experience.

Unfortunately, the more you upset people, the better you get at identifying the factors that caused the problem!

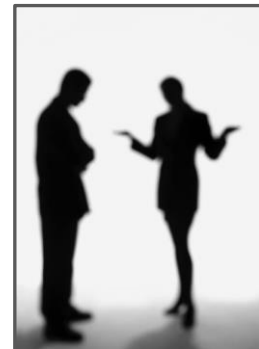


Being informed by the person themselves

This is where the person explains that your action or words have upset them and have offended them.

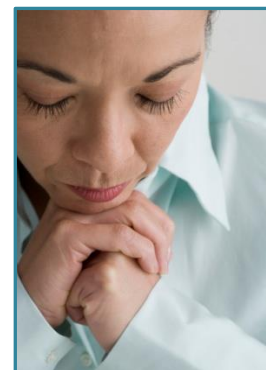
Any situation where a person discloses that you have upset them should be seen as a positive because it gives you the opportunity to rectify things as opposed to having matters simmer away, get worse and turn into a much bigger problem than is really necessary.

You will never get a better chance to put things right than where the person involved comes up to you and tells you about the issue.



Remember:

- It isn't always your fault – the misunderstanding may be caused by their misinterpretation of facts or words
- Be open-minded to their assertion that you said or did something unacceptable – don't immediately become defensive and start trying to defend a position that is essentially wrong or indefensible
- Apologise where necessary – it is truly amazing how many issues, disputes, misunderstandings and conflicts can be successfully resolved by a simple yet genuine and sincere apology
- Take steps to make sure you don't repeat any actions or statements that gave rise to the issue – this should apply even where you believe you were genuinely not 'at fault'. The crux of the decision to change your actions or words should not be whether you are, in fact right or wrong in what you said or did, but whether or not it actually gave offence or upset someone.



Being told by another person that you have upset someone

It may be a staff member who tells you that you have upset another staff member or annoyed a customer, a supervisor resulting from a personal observation or complaint or another person within the group to which a person belongs.

Where you are informed by a third party that you have upset someone, it may be best to be guided by their perception regarding the situation about what you should do in response.



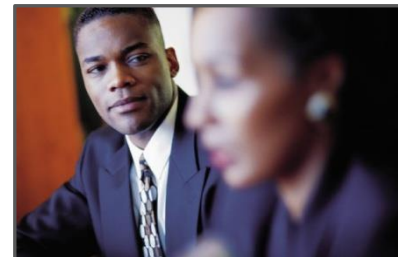
In many cases they will simply want to let you know about what you have done. They often do not want any action to be taken, or even an apology to be given. If however they indicate that an apology or some other action is appropriate, this must be followed up as you deem fitting for the circumstances that apply.

2.2 Address difficulties with the appropriate people and seek assistance from team leaders or others where required

Introduction

Where cross-cultural misunderstandings occur, efforts to resolve the situation should be made with the person concerned.

This applies whether you identified the problem in the first place, or if the situation was brought to your attention by the person themselves or a third party.



But addressing difficulties and resolving them is not always a straight-forward task or one that can be readily achieved.

There are bound to be many situations where, despite your best efforts and most determined attempts, there seems nothing you can do to rectify or retrieve the situations.

That's when you must make sure you don't just give up and walk away. This is when you must go and get help from others.

Dealing with customers

Not all cross-cultural misunderstandings will occur with customers but many will.

You will no doubt have heard of the saying 'The customer is always right' and it is an important one to remember in hospitality, tourism and events. It means that even if you were right and the customer was wrong, the customer is still right.

This may sound a little harsh but it is, for better or for worse, the way things are in the industry. In essence, it means we need the customer far more than the customer needs us, hence we must do everything we can, whether we like it or not, to keep them happy and keep them coming back.



Naturally there are limits as to what you are expected to do. For instance you are never expected to do anything that is illegal, unsafe or which demeans or humiliates you.

Another industry expression is 'No-one ever won an argument with a customer'. This means that even if you win the verbal argument, you lose in the long run because the customer will take their money and spend it elsewhere.

It is, after all, said that 'customers vote with their feet' meaning they always have the option of using their feet to walk out of your business and into someone else's.

Very few customers are really obliged to spend their money with us. They nearly always have the right to choose who they will favour with their spending.

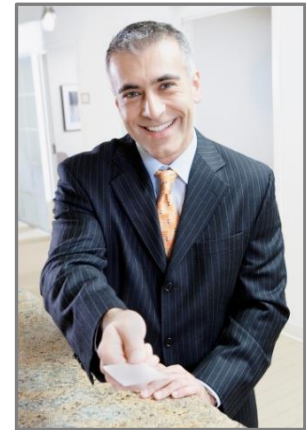
Scope of authority

Most staff are given guidelines as to what action they can take in the workplace without having to get special permission from management.

This is referred to as their 'scope of authority'.

The scope of authority may relate to:

- Their ability to act on behalf of the venue
- Their authority to spend money on behalf of the venue
- Their authority to act in given situations – such as when there is a complaint, in emergencies, accepting bookings or making special deals.



In relation to addressing cross-cultural misunderstandings which often involves resolving customer complaints, establishments may give staff standard scopes of authority to respond in standard ways such as:

- Offering a free product – glass of drink or free dessert
- Offering a service – such as dry cleaning
- Offering a set percentage discount on advertised selling prices.



The important thing to remember is to only act in resolving cross-cultural misunderstandings in-line with your specifically designated scope of authority.

Where your scope of authority is insufficient to deal with the problem, you should seek assistance from others.

Seeking help from others is integrated into the suggested techniques for dealing with such situations set out in section 2.4 (below).

Keys in involving other people are to:

- Make every genuine and realistic effort to resolve the issue yourself – try not to develop a reputation for needing other people to fight your battles
- Act quickly once the decision to involve someone else has been taken – don't delay. Delays only inflame a bad situation



- Make sure you give them all the facts – this includes the good, the bad and the ugly: you must tell them all that was said, all that was done including the bits that may not reflect well on you. Telling lies about the situation only makes it more difficult to fix the problem and the truth usually comes out making things more difficult for you next time round. It is almost impossible to shake a reputation for dishonesty and that reputation can follow you around the industry even though you may change employers
- Try to stay around to listen and learn from how they handle the situation.

Tips when addressing conflict and misunderstandings

When dealing with a cross-cultural misunderstanding it is important to remember that:

- Quick identification of a misunderstanding can prevent a conflict from occurring – a misunderstanding that is not addressed can quickly and unnecessarily involve others and have greater consequences than were really necessary
- When difficulties or misunderstandings occur, all possible cultural differences should be taken into consideration – standing in the other person's shoes can give a better perspective about the issue
- All efforts should be taken to resolve the misunderstanding as quickly as possible, taking cultural considerations into account during the process – the key is to individualise the context of the misunderstanding as appropriate for the people who are involved
- If appropriate, or where it is an establishment requirement, all issues and problems must be referred to the appropriate person for attention after the initial issue has been resolved, so that action can be taken to prevent recurrence
- Putting yourself in the other person's shoes and seeing the other side of an issue can help to put your stance into a better perspective
- Frustration or impatience should be avoided at all times – the focus must be on respect and sensitivity.



An open-minded person will always be better able to resolve misunderstandings and conflict than someone with a set bias, or someone who holds a stereotypical view of others.

2.3 Consider possible cultural differences when difficulties or misunderstandings occur

Introduction

It is possible that the cause of differences and difficulties are due to traditional service problems such as poor service, slow service, low-quality products or unclean rooms. However when dealing with people from diverse backgrounds it is also possible that cultural differences have caused the problems.

This section will take a further look at what issues may be involved where this is the case.

Sensitivity and respect

We have stressed the need to be sensitive and respectful to people from other cultures. This is not only an essential element in what is a service industry but it is a critical tool in addressing and resolving misunderstandings.



The theory suggests that when faced with a situation where there is an obvious misunderstanding with the other person being from another culture, it will pay to consider whether or not the problem can be traced back to a misunderstanding based on cultural differences.

Naturally, not all misunderstandings will be rooted in cultural difference, but it will certainly help to clear the air if you know that this is not the problem.

Possible cultural differences and needs

Misunderstandings in cross-cultural communication can occur as a result of the following cultural differences and needs:

Language spoken

It is possible that one party thought they used a word in an appropriate context, but it may have been misinterpreted. This lack of a comprehensive understanding of a language can lead to many of the problems encountered.



It is further possible that the lack of, say, an establishment to have a staff member who can communicate effectively with a person from a different language speaking background will give rise to frustration and annoyance.

Customers and colleagues may also have a strict position on bad language that causes an issue. For example, your personal broad-minded approach to bad language may not be shared by others and they may be upset or offended when they hear you use certain words. As a blanket statement, there is no room in the hospitality, tourism or events industry for staff to use bad language.

People from a different language speaking background can also be confused, embarrassed or offended by the use of local terms so this is best avoided.

Forms of address

Different cultures use different forms of address when greeting.

Where we use what we regard as a standard, acceptable and polite greeting, there is always the potential that the recipient of the greeting can feel affronted when we fail to conform to their culturally-based expectations.

One culture may not observe the same use of titles that we consider to be normal and polite. Our failure to use their system of address is not necessarily indicative of any lack of respect, or intention to cause offence but it can nonetheless create confusion, misunderstanding and be indicative of a lack of knowledge and care regarding the relevant culture.



For example, guests may feel that if we are unable to greet them appropriately then we can't meet their other culturally-based needs and wants.

It is interesting to read the article at <http://www.orvillejenkins.com/whatisculture/greetingscul.html> in order to gain more information about the way different cultures greet each other.

Levels of formality/informality

There is always a need for us to act professionally in the industry and part of that requirement is a need to act in a manner appropriate to the venue where we are working.

Some properties may encourage a more relaxed style while others insist on a much more formal level of service.

In either case there is the possibility that the level of formality can give unintended offence to guests.

A relaxed approach may give the impression that staff are inappropriately over-familiar and rude. A very formal approach may give the unintended impression that staff are removed and detached, uncaring, unfriendly and disinterested from the customer and their needs.

In addition, there is also the possibility that a guest or another staff member may try to adopt and use what they believe to be a local 'attitude' when talking or interacting with us believing that this is the approach we prefer.

In many of these cases this orientation can often lead to situations where the user gets it wrong and appears over-familiar and too friendly or the opposite.

In these circumstances we need to be able to recognise the situation for what it is and ensure we are not overly sensitive and do not take offence too readily.

Check out the following website to find out more about levels of style and levels of formality:

- <http://www.courses.vcu.edu/ENG-652/tbuchanan/levels.htm>.

Non-verbal behaviour

It is always possible that, through a simple lack of knowledge and not due to any bad intentions whatsoever, someone has used some gesture in the wrong context.

Because non-verbal communication is so powerful, we must be constantly alert to misunderstandings and potential misinterpreting in this area.

We should be proactive in identifying the 'good' and 'bad' forms of non-verbal cues from culture we regularly deal with.

Where you have no real knowledge about the body language of another country or culture, it is best to avoid using overt gestures just in case they give unintended offence.



For further information about appropriate non-verbal communication go to <http://www.multicultural.qld.gov.au/>. Click on 'Training' and then 'Cross-cultural communication'.

Work ethic

Generally speaking, guests expect us as staff to have an appropriate work ethic. They expect us to be polite, to offer excellent levels of service, to meet their needs and to be helpful.

When they see us ignoring their presence or not attending to their needs they can become disappointed and disgruntled. The danger is that they misinterpret this lack of professionalism as some sort of deliberate negative action aimed specifically at them because of their culture or background.

A similar problem can exist in relation to other staff with whom you work.

Staff from another country may have a work ethic that demands they are focused and professional at all times. These people may find it difficult to accept a lesser standard of commitment from local workers and this can lead to negative feelings from both sides.

It is to be expected that everyone's attitude to work is different and some people may work harder than we do, while others may work less hard.

Central to this discussion is the impression that these working hard or less hard images send to other people.

A person who works hard may be regarded as just trying to please the boss by someone else, and avoided or even ridiculed for that reason.

Another person may regard that high level of work as normal, while another may see it as being slack and regard the person as lazy and to be avoided, while another person acknowledges it for what it is - hard work.



Visit [http://www.up.ac.za/dspace/bitstream/2263/3873/1/Mafunisa_Positive \(2000\).pdf](http://www.up.ac.za/dspace/bitstream/2263/3873/1/Mafunisa_Positive%20(2000).pdf) for interesting information on work ethic and multi-culturalism.

Personal grooming and dress

All staff are expected to comply with the requirements established by the employer but, naturally, these standards don't apply to customers.

Without doubt some people dress to impress, and without doubt others dress to shock.

We need to look beyond the clothes and grooming to what the person is about. We must ensure that we don't stereotype people simply on the basis of, say, their national dress, or grooming preferences that may be influenced by their cultural heritage.

The most important things to remember in relation to this are to:

- Not stare at people who are dressed differently – this applies especially to people who are dressed in their national dress
- Not make public derogatory comment about the way a customer presents themselves – it is however acceptable to make a positive and complimentary remark.



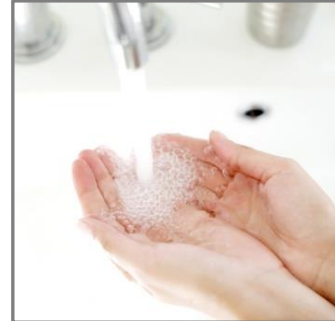
Hygiene habits

Different cultures can have hygiene habits and activities that are different to what you may regard as normal.

These variances should be accepted and accommodated and you must refrain from making adverse or negative comment.

These differences can include:

- The extent and timing of bathing or washing
- Frequency of bathing
- General ablution habits or styles
- Emphasis placed on personal hygiene – especially in relation to body odour.



Family, social obligations and status

Some cultures place an extremely high value on family. Nothing is more important than their family, including work obligations.

This priority is part of their cultural heritage, and any colleague so affected should not be condemned for their orientation to work.

Similarly, in certain circumstances they may have to attend various social functions because failure to attend could indicate a significant lack of respect.

In regard to guests it is also important to determine understand that the role and status of females can differ between cultures. Some other cultures regard males as holding primary status and will expect your communication to be aimed solely at them, regarding inclusion of females into the conversation as bad mannered or unnecessary.

In yet other cultures, the role of women is quite different and a failure to include them in conversations or to speak directly to them will definitely be seen as rude.

Observance of special religious, feast or other celebratory days

People from different countries treat these occasions differently. Some may not worry about them, whilst others take them very seriously.

They might be required by their faith to take time off from work to attend or observe a religious event, or take a break during traditional working hours to pray.

Check out the following for more information:

- <http://www.interfaithcalendar.org/>
- http://moscow.usembassy.gov/links/links.php?record_id=holiday_religious
- <http://www.usinfo.pl/aboutusa/holidays/ethnic.htm>
- <http://www.islam-usa.com/pray1.html>.



Customs, beliefs and values

It is accepted that a shared system of customs, beliefs and values is what underpins the core of any culture.

It is the variation in these customs, values and beliefs that creates the central differences that exist between cultures.

Classic examples of the differences that can exist relate to:

- The vastly different attitude that different cultures have towards cows
- The way that Eskimos greet each other compared to the way Asians do
- The variations in beliefs that exist between different religions or belief systems
- The different values that certain people place on lifestyle choices.



These differences in orientations are usually learned by people from birth and become central to the definition of who that person is and how they see themselves. Naturally, to challenge this perspective is to disrespect them and to raise all sorts of negative issues.

The key when seeking to understand and accommodate these variations is to realise that you don't have to apply these customs, beliefs and values in your life, you only have to respect and accommodate them in relation to the customers you serve and the colleagues you work with.

The following websites provide more information on this topic:

- <http://internationaleye.wordpress.com/culture04/>
- <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Meal>
- <http://iml.jou.ufl.edu/projects/Fall02/Capulong/customs.html>

Product preferences

It is to be expected that people from different countries and cultures have different needs, wants and preferences in relation to product and service preferences.

These preferences may be based on:

- Wanting to try something from the country in which they are travelling – to sample the domestic product or to experience a product for which the host area is famous
- Wanting to re-experience something from their home country – to help them maintain their link with their roots
- Insisting that they are not served or sold anything from certain countries – these can be countries with whom their country is at war or with whom there have been hostilities in the past
- Ensuring products meet the demands of religious beliefs.



2.4 Make efforts to resolve misunderstandings, taking account of cultural considerations

Introduction

When faced with a misunderstanding in the workplace, we must be prepared to think about all cross-cultural factors likely to affect the situation.

This requirement must apply to situations that involve both customers and colleagues.

In many cases, it is only when cross-cultural factors are considered, that the matter can be truly resolved because it is these factors that may have caused the problem or which give the problem its true context.

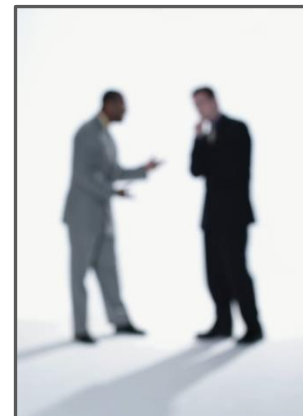
When a cross-cultural misunderstanding occurs with a customer, it is necessary for service staff to take the appropriate steps to find a resolution.

All talk should be honest, explained clearly, briefly and in simple unbiased terms.

Actions that can help resolve the situation

This may involve you in:

- Discussing the issue in a courteous manner – which will demonstrate a desire to fix the problem
- Speaking directly with the person concerned in a respectful way
- Apologising for offence or misunderstanding that may have been caused – even where there is a belief that you personally did not say or do anything that genuinely merits an apology
- Taking time to talk with the person concerned – to truly identify the relevant aspects of the situation and determine the facts and feelings involved in the situations
- Asking for advice from the other party – to work out how similar future problems may be avoided or to determine what action to take in the future when a similar problem arises
- Seeking advice from a supervisor or manager about the issue – to gain the benefit of their experience with similar circumstances
- Attending mediation – where there is a dispute between staff this provides an opportunity for both parties to air their views in front of an independent third person. This third party acts as a mediator and may have the final decision on the course of action to be taken. This action may include further training or education, or implementing in-house team building programs
- Enrolling in a language class - to improve first or second language skills that will help avert language-based problems
- Enrolling in other courses that may assist in improving cultural awareness or interpersonal skills.



Being aware that other cultures have different value systems, beliefs and priorities, enables us to view the personal actions of others from a more balanced and informed perspective.

It moves us from the stance of “we are right, they are wrong”, and allows us to accept that something different is not necessarily wrong – it’s just different: no more, no less!

2.5 Refer issues and problems to the appropriate team leader/supervisor for follow up

Introduction

There may be a need in your workplace to refer any issues relating to cross-cultural issues to management. This can be to help them ensure they discharge their responsibilities in relation to Equal Opportunity legislation.

In other situations there may only be a need to refer unresolved issues to management, so that they can assist in finding an acceptable and effective solution that accommodates, to the best extent possible, everyone’s culturally based needs.

Note that management are often faced with a difficult situation in relation to this as they are often required to accommodate the needs, wants and preferences of a customer or staff member from another culture while still at the same time respecting the needs, wants and preferences of local employees.



Know when to refer issues to management

It is always important to know when and where to draw the line in relation to any cross-cultural misunderstanding.

In this context there are two things to consider:

Notify the appropriate person when you don’t seem to be making any headway in reaching a resolution

This commonly occurs where no positive progress seems to be occurring and things are just getting worse.

This general involves situations where emotions are becoming more obvious. This might include crying, threats, swearing, aggressive behaviour, excessive gestures. Those involved appear to be adopting an entrenched position that doesn’t appear to hold any room for compromise or movement towards a genuine solution.



Notify the appropriate person after you believe you have come to a solution

This should be done so that any necessary follow-up and debriefing can be arranged.

This follow-up action can include:

- Revisions to standard operating procedure within the establishment – such as changes to policies, procedures, training manuals or operational checklists
- Inclusion of the issues at staff meetings and briefing sessions – so that other staff can learn from whatever was the cause of the problem or issue

- Making contact with those involved in order to:
 - Demonstrate their concern in relation to the matter
 - Ensure that the agreed solution has, in fact, genuinely resolved the situation.

Who should problems be referred to?

Depending on the establishment, and its organisational structure, the appropriate person could be:

- Your team leader
- Your supervisor
- The manager
- The owner.



Conclusion

In conclusion, working in the hospitality and tourism industry is truly an international experience. The people you interact with on a daily basis will come from all corners of the globe, each with their own beliefs, customs, languages, religions, experiences and expectations.

As a staff member in this global industry, it is your role to ensure that everyone receives friendly quality service, regardless of their origin.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

2.1 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Possible causes of conflict and misunderstanding
- How to identify issues.

2.2 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- How to deal with customers when conflicts arise
- Scope of authority staff may have
- Tips when addressing conflict and misunderstandings.

2.3 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- How to exhibit respect and sensitivity
- Possible cultural differences and needs.

2.4 To fulfil the requirements of this Work Project you are asked to research and identify:

- Actions that can help resolve the situation
 - When to refer issues to management
 - Who should problems be referred to.
-

Summary

Deal with cross cultural misunderstandings

Identify issues which may cause conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace:

- What is conflict and misunderstanding?
- Possible causes of conflict and misunderstanding
- How to identify issues.

Address difficulties with the appropriate people and seek assistance from team leaders or others where required:

- Dealing with customers
- Scope of authority
- Tips when addressing conflict and misunderstandings.

Consider possible cultural differences when difficulties or misunderstandings occur:

- Sensitivity and respect
- Possible cultural differences and needs.

Make efforts to resolve misunderstandings, taking account of cultural considerations:

- Actions that can help resolve the situation.

Refer issues and problems to the appropriate team leader/supervisor for follow up:

- Know when to refer issues to management
- Who should problems be referred to
- Conclusion.

Presentation of written work

1. Introduction

It is important for students to present carefully prepared written work. Written presentation in industry must be professional in appearance and accurate in content. If students develop good writing skills whilst studying, they are able to easily transfer those skills to the workplace.

2. Style



Students should write in a style that is simple and concise. Short sentences and paragraphs are easier to read and understand. It helps to write a plan and at least one draft of the written work so that the final product will be well organized. The points presented will then follow a logical sequence and be relevant. Students should frequently refer to the question asked, to keep 'on track'. Teachers recognize and are critical of work that does not answer the question, or is 'padded' with irrelevant material. In summary, remember to:

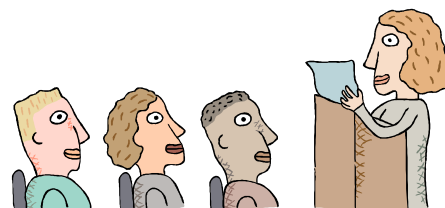
- Plan ahead
- Be clear and concise
- Answer the question
- Proofread the final draft.

3. Presenting Written Work

Types of written work

Students may be asked to write:

- Short and long reports
- Essays
- Records of interviews
- Questionnaires
- Business letters
- Resumes.



Format

All written work should be presented on A4 paper, single-sided with a left-hand margin. If work is word-processed, one-and-a-half or double spacing should be used. Handwritten work must be legible and should also be well spaced to allow for ease of reading. New paragraphs should not be indented but should be separated by a space. Pages must be numbered. If headings are also to be numbered, students should use a logical and sequential system of numbering.

Cover Sheet

All written work should be submitted with a cover sheet stapled to the front that contains:

- The student's name and student number
- The name of the class/unit
- The due date of the work
- The title of the work
- The teacher's name
- A signed declaration that the work does not involve plagiarism.

Keeping a Copy

Students must keep a copy of the written work in case it is lost. This rarely happens but it can be disastrous if a copy has not been kept.

Inclusive language

This means language that includes every section of the population. For instance, if a student were to write 'A nurse is responsible for the patients in her care at all times' it would be implying that all nurses are female and would be excluding male nurses.

Examples of appropriate language are shown on the right:

Mankind	<i>Humankind</i>
Barman/maid	<i>Bar attendant</i>
Host/hostess	<i>Host</i>
Waiter/waitress	<i>Waiter or waiting staff</i>

Recommended reading

Axtell, Roger; 2007 (1st edition); *Gestures: The Do's and Taboos of Body Language Around the World*; Wiley

Deresky, Helen; 2010 (7th edition); *International Management: Managing Across Borders and Cultures, Text and Cases*; Prentice Hall

Dresser, Norine; 2005 (Revised edition); *Multicultural Manners: Essential Rules of Etiquette for the 21st Century*; Wiley

Liu, Shuang; 2010 (1st edition); *Introducing Intercultural Communication: Global Cultures and Contexts*; Sage Publications Ltd

Morrison, Terri; 2006 (2nd edition); *Kiss, Bow, or Shake Hands (The Bestselling Guide to Doing Business in More than 60 Countries)*; Adams Media

Mueller, Barbara; 2007 (1st edition); *Communicating With the Multicultural Consumer; Theoretical and Practical Perspectives*; Prentice Hall

Peterson, Brooks; 2004 (1st edition); *Cultural Intelligence: A Guide to Working with People from Other Cultures*; Nicholas Brealey Publishing

Trainee evaluation sheet

Work in a socially diverse environment

The following statements are about the competency you have just completed.

Please tick the appropriate box	Agree	Don't Know	Do Not Agree	Does Not Apply
There was too much in this competency to cover without rushing.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most of the competency seemed relevant to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency was at the right level for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I got enough help from my trainer.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The amount of activities was sufficient.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency allowed me to use my own initiative.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My training was well-organized.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer had time to answer my questions.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I understood how I was going to be assessed.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I was given enough time to practice.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer feedback was useful.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Enough equipment was available and it worked well.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The activities were too hard for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐

The best things about this unit were:

The worst things about this unit were:

The things you should change in this unit are:

Trainee self-assessment checklist

As an indicator to your Trainer/Assessor of your readiness for assessment in this unit please complete the following and hand to your Trainer/Assessor.

Work in a socially diverse environment

		Yes	No*
Element 1: Communicate with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds			
1.1	Value customers and colleagues from different cultural groups and treat them with respect and sensitivity	☐	☐
1.2	Take into consideration cultural differences in all verbal and non-verbal communication	☐	☐
1.3	Attempt to overcome language barriers	☐	☐
1.4	Obtain assistance from colleagues, reference books or outside organisations when required	☐	☐
Element 2: Deal with cross cultural misunderstandings			
2.1	Identify issues which may cause conflict or misunderstanding in the workplace	☐	☐
2.2	Address difficulties with the appropriate people and seek assistance from team leaders or others where required	☐	☐
2.3	Consider possible cultural differences when difficulties or misunderstandings occur	☐	☐
2.4	Make efforts to resolve misunderstandings, taking account of cultural considerations	☐	☐
2.5	Refer issues and problems to the appropriate team leader/supervisor for follow up	☐	☐

Statement by Trainee:

I believe I am ready to be assessed on the following as indicated above:

Signed: _____

Date: _____

Note:

For all boxes where a **No*** is ticked, please provide details of the extra steps or work you need to do to become ready for assessment.

